

moment he walked onstage and opened his mouth, but I'll tell you something, my friend. Something forty years in high schools and sixty years of living has taught me and taught me well. Artistic talent is far more common than the talent to nurture artistic talent. Any parent with a hard hand can crush it, but to nurture it is much more difficult. That's a talent you have, and in much greater supply than the one that drove this." She tapped the sheaf of pages on the coffee table in front of her.

"I don't know what to say."

"Say thank you, and compliment me on my acute judgment."

"Thanks. And your insight is only exceeded by your good looks."

That brought the smile back, dryer than ever. "Don't exceed your brief, George."

"Yes, Miz Mimi."

The smile disappeared. She leaned forward. The blue eyes behind her glasses were too big, swimming in her face. The skin under her tan was yellowish, and her formerly taut cheeks were hollow. When had this happened? Had Deke noticed? But that was ridic, as the kids said. Deke wouldn't notice that his socks were mismatched until he took them off at night. Probably not even then.

She said, "Phil Bateman is no longer just threatening to retire, he's done pulled the pin and tossed the grenade, as our delightful Coach Borman would say. Which means there's a vacancy on the English faculty. Come and teach full-time at DCHS, George. The kids like you, and after the junior-senior play, the community thinks you're the second coming of Alfred Hitchcock. Deke is just waiting to see your application—he told me so just last night. Please. Publish this under a pseudonym, if you have to, but come and teach. That's what you were meant to do."

I wanted badly to say yes, because she was right. My job wasn't writing books, and it certainly wasn't killing people, no matter how much they deserved killing. And there was Jodie. I'd come to it as a stranger who had been displaced from his home era as well as his hometown, and the first words spoken to me here—by Al

Stevens, homesick, or redefined you, you'll kill its leading citizens water. But the waters here yet. Maybe . . .

"George? You have to 'That's called thinking. She put her hands to a comic O of apology. wheat."

I paid no attention, to notes. I no longer had to school year started in September, June, with whom Mar was a battle Oswald would power bureaucracy off against (mentary) cleverness, but then onto American soil until Texas . . .

"Meems, the school year doesn't it?"

"Always. The kids who n down."

. . . as for Texas, the Oswald tenth of June, 1962.

"And any teaching contract? As in one year?"

"With an option to renew if right? Then you've got yourself a She laughed, clapped her hands out. "Marvelous! Huggies